



Lemon grass makes a soothing tea.

Parts Used Leaves, essential oil.

Constituents Lemon grass contains a volatile oil with citral (about 70%) and citronellal as its main constituents. Both are markedly sedative.

History & Folklore Lemon grass is cultivated for its oil, which is used as a culinary flavoring, a scent, and medicinally.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Lemon grass is principally taken as a tea to remedy digestive problems. It relaxes the muscles of the stomach and gut, relieves cramping pains and flatulence, and is particularly suitable for children. In the Caribbean, lemon grass is primarily regarded as a fever-reducing herb (especially where there is significant congestion). It is applied externally as a poultice or as diluted essential oil to ease pain and arthritis. In India, a paste of the leaves is smeared on patches of ringworm.

Related Species *C. martinii* and *C. nardus* yield essential oils that are widely used in soaps and detergents. In Tanzania, medicine men smoke the flowers of *C. densiflorus* to produce dreams foretelling the future.

Caution Do not take the essential oil internally without professional supervision.

Cynara scolymus
syn. *C. cardunculus* (Asteraceae)

Artichoke

Description Perennial herb growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has large, thistle-like leaves, grey-green above and woolly white beneath, and very large purple-green flower heads.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Mediterranean region, artichoke thrives in rich loam in warm temperate climates. Commercially grown plants are renewed after 4 years. The unopened flower heads and leaves are picked in early summer.

Parts Used Flower heads, leaves, root.

Constituents All parts of the plant contain the sesquiterpene lactone cynaropicrin (which is strongly bitter) and much inulin. The leaves also contain cynarin, which has liver-protective properties.

History & Folklore Artichokes were greatly valued by the ancient Greeks and Romans. Dioscorides (1st century CE) recommended applying the mashed roots to the armpit or elsewhere on the body to sweeten offensive odors.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Artichoke is a valuable medicinal plant. Like milk thistle (*Silybum marianus*, p. 137), it benefits the liver, protecting against toxins and infection. Though the leaves are particularly effective, all parts of the plant are bitter and stimulate digestive secretions, especially bile. This makes artichoke useful for the treatment of gallbladder problems, nausea, indigestion, and abdominal distension, with the added benefit that it lowers blood cholesterol levels. A home recipe from the Mediterranean region uses fresh artichoke leaf juice mixed with wine or water as a liver tonic. Artichoke is also taken during the early stages of type 2 diabetes. It is a good food for diabetics, as it significantly lowers blood sugar. It is also a useful diuretic, and in France it has been used to treat rheumatic conditions.

Research Research with laboratory animals in the late 1990s has shown that artichoke has a powerful positive effect on the liver. Artichoke extracts, and cynaroside in particular, appear to reduce cholesterol synthesis in the liver, while leaf extracts are strongly antioxidant and liver protective.



Artichoke flower heads are nourishing and beneficial for the liver and digestion.

Cyperus esculentus (Cyperaceae)

Chufa, Tiger Nut

Description Erect, grass-like plant growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has cylindrical brown tubers, lance-shaped leaves, and rays of small spikes of green-brown flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Mediterranean region, chufa was first introduced to Spain and North Africa by the Arabs. It now grows worldwide, including in India. The tubers (called "nuts") are unearthed in winter and summer.

Parts Used Tubers.

Constituents Chufa contains 20–36% fixed oil, known as chufa or tiger nut oil.

History & Folklore Chufa nuts have been found in the excavations of the earliest settlements in the Nile Valley, and since ancient times they have remained a popular food in the region. The Greek physician Dioscorides, writing in the 1st century CE, mentions their ability to comfort the stomach.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Chufa is regarded as a digestive tonic, having a heating and drying effect on the digestive system and alleviating flatulence. It also promotes urine production and menstruation. The juice is taken to heal ulcers of the mouth and gums. Ayurvedic medicine classifies the nuts as digestive, tonic, and aphrodisiac.

Related Species Many other species of *Cyperus* are used as foods or medicines. For example, in Chinese herbal medicine *C. rotundus* is used as a liver tonic, to counter indigestion and to promote menstruation. *C. stolonifera*, native to tropical regions of Asia and Australia, is thought to ease stomach pain and act as a heart stimulant. Perhaps the most famous *Cyperus* species of all is papyrus (*C. papyrus*). This plant provided fiber for the first writing paper, invented by the ancient Egyptians. Papyrus was also chewed like sugar cane, and used medicinally in eye compresses and to bandage wounds.

Cypripedium pubescens
(Orchidaceae)

Lady's Slipper, American Valerian

Description Perennial orchid with several stems sheathed by broad lance-shaped leaves. Has beautiful, complex golden-yellow and purple flowers in late summer.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb is native to eastern North America. Its natural habitat is woods and pastures, but due to overharvesting, it is rarely found in the wild. It is cultivated to a limited degree.